Syllabus

CONEY ISLAND AUTO PARTS UNLIMITED, INC. *v.* BURTON, CHAPTER 7 TRUSTEE FOR VISTA-PRO AUTOMOTIVE, LLC

CERTIORARI TO THE UNITED STATES COURT OF APPEALS FOR THE SIXTH CIRCUIT

No. 24–808. Argued November 4, 2025—Decided January 20, 2026

The question in this case is whether Federal Rule of Civil Procedure 60(c)(1)'s requirement that parties make Rule 60(b) motions within a "reasonable time" applies to a motion seeking relief from an allegedly void judgment under Rule 60(b)(4). Vista-Pro Automotive, LLC, entered bankruptcy in 2014 and initiated adversarial proceedings against Coney Island Auto Parts Unlimited, Inc., to collect $50,000 in allegedly unpaid invoices. Vista-Pro attempted to serve process on Coney Island by mail but purportedly failed to comply with Federal Rule of Bankruptcy Procedure 7004(b)(3)'s mail-service requirements. Coney Island did not file an answer, and the Bankruptcy Court entered a default judgment. Over the next six years, Vista-Pro's bankruptcy trustee attempted to enforce the judgment. These efforts bore fruit in 2021 when a marshal seized funds from Coney Island's bank account in satisfaction of the judgment. Coney Island filed a motion to vacate the judgment under Federal Rule of Civil Procedure 60, arguing that Vista-Pro's failure to make proper service rendered the judgment void. The Bankruptcy Court denied relief, holding that Coney Island failed to abide by Rule 60's requirement that parties make motions for relief within a "reasonable time." The District Court and the Court of Appeals for the Sixth Circuit affirmed.

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Held: Rule 60(c)(1)'s reasonable-time limit applies to a motion alleging that a judgment is void under Rule 60(b)(4). Pp. 158–162.

(a) The plain text of Rule 60(c)(1) provides that a "motion under Rule 60(b) must be made within a reasonable time," and because a motion for relief from an allegedly void judgment is a "motion under Rule 60(b)," the reasonable-time limit applies. The structure of Rule 60 confirms the plain-text interpretation. Rule 60 expressly modifies the default reasonable-time limit, imposing a 1-year limit on Rule 60(b) motions alleging mistakes, new evidence, or fraud. Yet the Rule does not include an analogous unlimited-time principle for motions alleging voidness. P. 158.

(b) The Court rejects the argument that because a "void judgment is a legal nullity," *United Student Aid Funds, Inc.* v. *Espinosa*, 559 U. S.

260, 270, no time limit should apply. Even if the passage of time cannot cure voidness, the same principle holds true for most legal errors, yet statutes and rules routinely limit the time during which a party can seek relief from a judgment infected by error. A party would need to show that some principle of law, such as the Due Process Clause, gives a party the right to allege voidness at any time, but Coney Island disclaims any such argument, and the Court cannot divine any such principle. Allowing parties to allege voidness at any time would have extreme implications, such as allowing parties to ignore deadlines for filing notices of appeal or petitions for certiorari when subject-matter jurisdiction is contested. The possibility that improper service is different from other legal errors because a party might not learn about proceedings until long after judgment issues does not help Coney Island. Rule 60(c)(1) accommodates such a scenario by imposing a reasonable-time requirement rather than a fixed time limit. In the context of a default judgment, it might be reasonable for a defendant not to seek relief before learning about a plaintiff's attempted enforcement. Pp. 159–160.

(c) The Court rejects Coney Island's argument that courts have historically allowed litigants to seek relief from void judgments at any time. No such historical consensus exists, and in any event, for Rule 60(b) motions, the Rule's text and structure take priority over historical practice. The Court also rejects Coney Island's reliance on *Insurance Corp. of Ireland* v. *Compagnie des Bauxites de Guinee*, 456 U. S. 694, as that case undermines Coney Island's plea for no time limits. Lastly, the Court rejects Coney Island's invocation of policy concerns, Rule 60's drafting history, and the canon of constitutional avoidance. To the extent that these interpretive tools carry any weight, they do so only when a Rule's language is ambiguous. Pp. 160–161.

109 F. 4th 438, affirmed.

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ALITO, J., delivered the opinion of the Court, in which ROBERTS, C. J., and THOMAS, KAGAN, GORSUCH, KAVANAUGH, BARRETT, and JACKSON, JJ., joined. SOTOMAYOR, J., filed an opinion concurring in the judgment, *post*, p. 162.

Daniel Ginzburg argued the cause and filed briefs for petitioner.

Lisa S. Blatt argued the cause for respondent. With her on the brief were *Charles L. McCloud*, *Erin M. Sielaff*, and *Phillip G. Young, Jr.*

JUSTICE ALITO delivered the opinion of the Court.

A party seeking relief from an allegedly void judgment may file a motion under Federal Rule of Civil Procedure 60(b)(4). Rule 60(c)(1) requires parties to make Rule 60(b) motions within a "reasonable time." We hold that this time limit applies to a motion alleging that a judgment is void.

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Vista-Pro Automotive, LLC, entered bankruptcy in 2014. As part of its bankruptcy litigation, Vista-Pro initiated adversarial proceedings against Coney Island Auto Parts Unlimited, Inc., to collect $50,000 in allegedly unpaid invoices. Vista-Pro attempted to serve process on Coney Island by mail, but in doing so, it purportedly failed to comply with the mail-service requirements in Federal Rule of Bankruptcy Procedure 7004(b)(3).

Coney Island did not file an answer in the adversarial proceedings, and the Bankruptcy Court entered a default judgment against the company in 2015. Over the next six years, Vista-Pro's bankruptcy trustee attempted to enforce that judgment against Coney Island. As part of these efforts, the trustee sent a demand letter to the company's CEO in April 2016. Lower courts concluded that this letter gave Coney Island notice of the judgment and the trustee's enforcement efforts.

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These efforts bore fruit in 2021 when a marshal seized funds from Coney Island's bank account in satisfaction of the judgment. In response, Coney Island filed a motion to vacate the judgment under Federal Rule of Civil Procedure 60. According to Coney Island, Vista-Pro's failure to make proper service rendered the judgment void.

The Bankruptcy Court denied relief. It held that Coney Island failed to abide by Rule 60's requirement that parties make motions for relief within a "reasonable time." The District Court and Court of Appeals for the Sixth Circuit